

States **KARNATAKA**

Disasters in the MAKING

The Government pulls out all the stops for hydroelectric projects in the power-starved state but biodiversity could be in peril



By Nirmala Ravindran

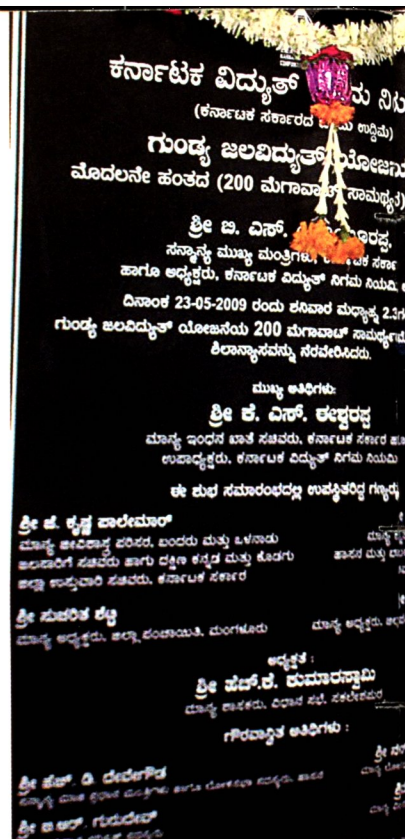
The B.S. Yeddyurappa-led BJP Government in Karnataka is clear about its priorities. Power figures very high on that list. With the state's total power requirement shooting up to 6,230 MW (August 2008) and the availability being 5,595 MW, the deficit of over 600 MW has put the Government in a tight spot. With two- to eight-hour daily power cuts in India's Silicon Valley, successive governments in the state have come in for major flak from the massive IT industry and ordinary citizens alike. Pushed to the defensive, the Government is now on a rampage, announcing power projects across the state. Three major projects at the districts of Raichur, Bellary and Hassan have been inaugurated in the last month alone.

While ecological experts and environmentalists have warned that these 'quick fix measures' are bound to have an adverse effect on the ecology of the region, the Government counters that these projects will help generate up to 6,000 MW of power in the next four years. "The move will help provide free electricity to more than 50 per cent of the farmers who are dependant on irrigation pumpsets," said Chief Minister Yeddyurappa, referring to the necessity of the Gundiya Power Project in Hassan district.

Though in the pipeline for over a

decade, what has come as a surprise is the Government's decision to inaugurate the Gundiya project even before it received critical clearances. Environmentalists, supported by local villagers, have been protesting for years now. Hundreds courted arrest the day Yeddyurappa arrived to lay the foundation stone; 26 were detained by the police. They alleged that the urgency in inaugurating the project showed the lack of transparency on the part of the Government as the Gundiya project is yet to receive clearances from the Ministry of Environment and Forests (MOEF) as well as the Ministry of Defence.

While the Government insists that it has shared details of the survey and the report with all the concerned parties, the local NGOs claim they have been able to source and obtain critical information only by filing RTI applications. Those working against the project say the Karnataka Power Corporation Limited (KPCL) is misleading the public. While the Government says only 451 hectares of virgin forest land will be affected, they contend that over 800 hectares of land will be submerged. "The project is not just about the river, dams and canals; there will be roads, townships and the need to create infrastructure in a fragile ecosystem like the Western Ghats, not to speak of the proximity to the reserve forests. It would be fatal for the government to go ahead with



this project," says lawyer and activist Kishore Kumar of the Malenadu Janapara Horata Samiti. Joining him in the agitation are several environmental groups as well as local village samitis in the region who insist the Government must reject the Environment Impact Assessment report for the project prepared by the Institute for Catchment Studies and Environment Management as the details in the reports have been proven to be false and inaccurate. "It is a hurried report with no consistency. The

63% of the country's evergreen plants are endemic to the forests of